

a great idea, either. It implies that if you did have the money, the kid would be getting a different answer. That's why no means no. Period.

There was a time when kids didn't go to toy stores. They weren't invited to every dinner party, either, and they certainly didn't get to eat in fine restaurants. Going to the mall wasn't a twice-weekly trip. It was saved for special occasions. Times are different now. Before your children participate in the adult consumer culture, they must be taught about money, its value, and who holds the purse strings in the family. And they must know it's not them.

5 Ways to Minimize Baby-Spending Madness

Introducing a child into your life doesn't mean you have to throw financial wisdom out the window. It means you need to be even more frugal now. Here are some tried-and-true tips my mother would agree with.

1. **Clothes.** Kids grow. All your new-baby needs are cotton onesies they can throw up on. They need a ton of those and some blankets. The mini-peacoat, the tiny leather biker jacket? Really? Skip them.
2. **Strollers.** It's sickening how expensive these things are. Growing up, I don't remember a lot of people even owning strollers. Now they're as tricked out as small vehicles, and often as big. Buy a good-quality used one.
3. **Day care.** This is a tricky topic because it involves conversations about who will stay home with the child and who will continue to work. In an era in which it can cost more than \$800 a month for full-time day care, these are worthy conversations. Do the math. If it turns out that living on one income will save you thousands of dollars in transportation costs, it might be worth it to forgo day care. Or ask friends or family nearby if they'll help out. Pay them, though. Don't prey on the goodwill of Grandma